

Vocabulary in Context

Chapter F8.1 — Half the English Block, and the Only Topic That Rewards Five Minutes a Day Over Twelve Hours in a Week

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MUST MASTER · WHY THIS IS THE HIGHEST-CONCENTRATION TOPIC IN THE PAPER

Of the twenty English questions in the 2023 paper, **ten were vocabulary in context** (PYQ-DERIVED, Blueprint §4.4).

Ten questions — 25 marks — from a single format. No other format in the entire 120-question paper carries that concentration. Not one accounting topic, not one labour statute.

It is also the format that behaves least like the rest of the manual. You cannot derive a word's meaning from first principles the way you can derive a mesh-link count. Vocabulary is **exposure over time**, which is why F8.0 §4.2 puts ten words a day into your evening routine rather than a chapter you read once.

Read §2 and §3 properly — those are the techniques that let you answer questions containing words you do not know. Then run the §5 list as a daily drip.

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0. How This Chapter Works

STUDY SESSION · CHAPTER F8.1

1. **Session 1** — The format, and the time budget (§1) ★★☆☆☆
2. **Session 2** — The five techniques for words you do not know (§2) ★★★★★
3. **Session 3** — Roots, prefixes and suffixes (§3) ★★★★★
4. **Session 4** — Confusable pairs (§4) ★★★★★
5. **Ongoing** — The word list (§5) as a **daily drip**, ten a day, per F8.0 §4.2
6. **Session 5** — Idioms worth knowing (§6) ★★☆☆☆

Then 40 graded questions in §7 — the largest bank in the manual, because the format's weight justifies it. F8.0's calendar splits them across two evenings in week 1 and re-drills them in weeks 4, 5, 7 and 9.

1. Session 1 — The Format ★★☆☆

Vocabulary questions come in four shapes, and all four appeared in some form in the papers analysed:

Shape	What it asks
Meaning in context	A word is used in a sentence; choose the closest meaning
Fill in the blank	Choose the word that best completes the sentence
Synonym or antonym	Choose the word closest or opposite in meaning
Confusable pair	Choose the correct one of two similar words

MUST MASTER · TWENTY TO THIRTY SECONDS, AND THEN MOVE

F8.0 §1.1 sets your target at **20 to 30 seconds** per vocabulary question, and the reason is worth stating plainly: **deliberating does not help**. Either the word is in your vocabulary, or the techniques in §2 will get you to an answer in twenty seconds, or neither will — and a further ninety seconds of staring changes nothing.

Ten vocabulary questions at 25 seconds is **four minutes**. The same ten at 70 seconds is **twelve minutes** — and the eight minutes lost are five mensuration problems you will not reach.

This is the format where speed is worth more than certainty. Answer, mark it, move.

2. Session 2 — Five Techniques for Words You Do Not Know ★★★★★

You will meet words you have never seen. These five techniques, in this order, will get you to an answer far more often than guessing.

2.1 Connotation — is the sentence praising or criticising?

The most powerful technique, and the fastest. Before considering meaning at all, ask whether the sentence carries a **positive** or **negative** charge. Then eliminate every option of the wrong charge.

*"The employer's conduct in concealing wage records was **egregious**."*

You may not know *egregious*. But "concealing wage records" is plainly **negative**, so any positive option — commendable, generous — is gone immediately. That often leaves two, and a 50% guess has an expected value of +0.83 marks.

Signposts of charge: *unfortunately, failed, despite, concealed, refused* signal negative; *successfully, commendably, achieved, ensured* signal positive.

2.2 Contrast and continuation signals

The connective tells you whether the missing word **agrees** with the rest of the sentence or **opposes** it.

Signal	Relationship	Words
Contrast	The blank opposes the other half	but, although, though, however, whereas, despite, notwithstanding, far from , rather than
Continuation	The blank agrees	and, moreover, furthermore, indeed, similarly, likewise
Cause and effect	The blank follows from the other half	because, therefore, consequently, since, hence

*"**Far from** being _____, the penalty was widely regarded as lenient."*

"Far from" signals contrast, and the other half says *lenient*. So the blank must mean the **opposite of lenient** — severe, harsh, **draconian**. The sentence has told you the answer without your knowing any of the options.

2.3 Word roots

Covered fully in §3. A word you have never seen may still decompose: *malfeasance* contains **mal-** (bad), *benevolent* contains **bene-** (good).

2.4 Part of speech

The grammatical slot often eliminates options outright. If the blank follows "*a matter of*", it needs a **noun** — so *principle*, not *principal* used adjectivally, and certainly not *principally*.

2.5 Collocation — what actually goes with what

Some words simply pair with others by convention. *Protestations* are **vehement**; a point is **moot**; credulity is **strained**; a fort is **held**. If an option produces a phrase no one would ever say, it is wrong even if its dictionary meaning fits.

THINK LIKE UPSC · THE ORDER TO APPLY THESE IN

Under time pressure, run them in this sequence and stop as soon as one option survives alone:

1. **Charge** — positive or negative? Eliminate the wrong charge
2. **Signal** — contrast or continuation? Does the blank agree or oppose?
3. **Root** — can I decompose any option?
4. **Part of speech** — does the slot need a noun, verb or adjective?
5. **Collocation** — does the phrase sound like English?

Steps 1 and 2 alone resolve a large share of questions in **under fifteen seconds**, and they require no vocabulary at all. That is why they come first.

3. Session 3 — Roots, Prefixes and Suffixes ★★★★★

3.1 Prefixes of quantity, direction and negation

Prefix	Meaning	Example
a-, an-	without	<i>amoral, anarchy</i>
ambi-	both	<i>ambiguous, ambivalent</i>
ante-	before	<i>antecedent</i>
anti-	against	<i>antipathy</i>
circum-	around	<i>circumvent, circumspect</i>
contra-, counter-	against	<i>contravene</i>
e-, ex-	out of	<i>exonerate, extricate</i>
extra-	beyond	<i>extraneous</i>
hyper-	excessive	<i>hyperbole</i>
hypo-	under	<i>hypothesis</i>
inter-	between	<i>intervene</i>
intra-	within	<i>intramural</i>
mal-	bad	<i>malfeasance, malign</i>
mono-	one	<i>monotonous</i>
poly-	many	<i>polyglot</i>
post-	after	<i>posthumous</i>
pre-	before	<i>precedent</i>
pro-	forward, in favour	<i>proponent</i>
retro-	backward	<i>retrospective</i>
sub-	under	<i>subordinate, subterfuge</i>

Prefix	Meaning	Example
super-, supra-	above	<i>supersede</i>
trans-	across	<i>transgress</i>

3.2 Roots that unlock the most words

Root	Meaning	Examples
bene	good	<i>benevolent, benefactor</i>
cred	believe	<i>credulity, incredulous, credible</i>
dict	say	<i>dictate, contradict, edict</i>
duc, duct	lead	<i>conduct, induce</i>
fid	faith	<i>fidelity, bona fide, diffident</i>
greg	flock	<i>gregarious, egregious, segregate</i>
loqu, log	speak	<i>loquacious, eloquent, colloquial</i>
mit, miss	send	<i>remit, remission</i>
path	feeling	<i>empathy, apathy, pathos</i>
pon, pos	place, put	<i>proponent, impose</i>
scrib, script	write	<i>prescribe, proscribe, inscribe</i>
spec, spic	look	<i>circumspect, perspicacious</i>
ten, tain	hold	<i>tenable, untenable, retain</i>
ver	truth	<i>veracity, verify, aver</i>
vert	turn	<i>avert, invert, subvert</i>
voc, vok	call, voice	<i>vociferous, evoke, equivocal</i>

MEMORY TECHNIQUE · TWO ROOTS THAT PAY FOR THEMSELVES

greg = flock. A *gregarious* person likes the flock. To *segregate* is to separate from the flock. And **egregious** — literally *out of the flock* — meant "standing out", and came to mean standing out for being **outstandingly bad**. One root, three exam words.

scrib = write, with the prefix deciding everything: to **prescribe** is to write *for* — to recommend. To **proscribe** is to write *against* — to forbid. **They are near-opposites and they are routinely offered against each other.** A doctor prescribes a medicine; a law proscribes a practice.

3.3 Suffixes that tell you the part of speech

Suffix	Makes	Example
-able, -ible	adjective: capable of	<i>tenable, credible</i>
-ous, -ious	adjective: full of	<i>verbose, censorious</i>
-ity, -ty	noun: quality	<i>veracity, alacrity</i>
-ment, -tion, -sion	noun: act or result	<i>discernment, remission</i>
-ify, -ise	verb: to make	<i>verify, scrutinise</i>
-ism	noun: doctrine	<i>altruism</i>
-cracy, -archy	rule by	<i>bureaucracy, oligarchy</i>

4. Session 4 — Confusable Pairs ★★★★★

The exam's cheapest question type, and the easiest to lose. Each pair differs by one or two letters and entirely in meaning.

Pair	Meanings
affect / effect	affect = to influence (verb) · effect = a result (noun), or to bring about (verb)
principal / principle	principal = chief, or a sum of money · principle = a rule or belief
stationary / stationery	stationary = not moving · stationery = writing materials
eminent / imminent	eminent = distinguished · imminent = about to happen
prescribe / proscribe	prescribe = to recommend · proscribe = to forbid
complement / compliment	complement = to complete · compliment = to praise
discreet / discrete	discreet = tactful · discrete = separate, distinct
elicit / illicit	elicit = to draw out · illicit = unlawful
ingenious / ingenuous	ingenious = clever · ingenuous = naive, artless
council / counsel	council = an assembly · counsel = advice, or a lawyer
censure / censor	censure = to criticise formally · censor = to suppress content
adapt / adopt	adapt = to adjust · adopt = to take up
precede / proceed	precede = to come before · proceed = to go forward
accede / exceed	accede = to agree or yield · exceed = to go beyond
moral / morale	moral = ethical · morale = spirit, confidence
respectfully / respectively	respectfully = with respect · respectively = in the order given

COMMON UPSC TRAP · THE THREE PAIRS MOST OFTEN TESTED

1. **principal / principle.** *Principle* is the **rule** — and it is the one with the noun-only meaning. "A matter of principle." Mnemonic: a **rule** ends in **-le**, like **principle**
2. **prescribe / proscribe.** Near-opposites, from §3.2. **Pro-scribe forbids**
3. **stationary / stationery.** **Station-e-ry** contains **e** for **envelopes**; **stationary** contains **a**, and means **at rest**

Note also that several of these words appear naturally in the administrative register this examination favours — *censure, accede, proscribe, ex parte* — which is not a coincidence. The setter draws from the vocabulary of governance.

5. Session 5 — The Word List ★★★★★

NOTE · WHAT THIS LIST IS, AND WHAT IT IS NOT

This is a **core list of about 140 high-frequency words**, chosen because they recur in competitive English papers and in the administrative register this examination uses.

It is not 720 words. F8.0 §4.2 asks for ten words a day for twelve weeks, and this list will carry you for the first fourteen days. After that, **extend it from your own reading** — every unfamiliar word in an F8.3 comprehension passage, an editorial, or an EPFO circular goes on your own list.

That is not a shortcut: **words harvested from real reading are better retained** than words from a printed list, because you first met them doing something else. The list is a starting stock, not the whole diet.

5.1 Words A to F

Word	Meaning
abate	to lessen, diminish
abstruse	difficult to understand
acquiesce	to accept passively
acumen	keen judgement
adamant	unyielding
admonish	to reprove gently
alacrity	brisk and cheerful willingness
allay	to relieve, calm
ambiguous	open to more than one meaning
ameliorate	to make better
amenable	willing to comply
anomaly	a deviation from the norm
apathy	lack of interest or feeling
arbitrary	based on whim, not reason
assiduous	diligent and persistent
audacious	boldly daring
austere	severe, without comfort
belligerent	aggressive, warlike
benevolent	kindly, well-meaning
brevity	shortness of expression
candid	frank, straightforward
capricious	given to sudden changes of mood
censure	to criticise formally

Word	Meaning
circumspect	cautious, considering all sides
circumvent	to find a way around
cogent	convincing, compelling
complacent	smugly self-satisfied
conciliate	to pacify, win over
condone	to overlook an offence
contentious	causing dispute
corroborate	to confirm with evidence
credulity	readiness to believe
culpable	deserving blame
cursor	hasty, superficial
deference	respectful submission
defunct	no longer operating
deleterious	harmful
deprecate	to express disapproval of
desultory	lacking plan, random
diffident	lacking self-confidence
dilatory	causing or given to delay
discern	to perceive clearly
disparate	essentially different
draconian	excessively harsh
ebullient	overflowing with enthusiasm
eclectic	drawing from many sources
efficacious	producing the intended result

Word	Meaning
egregious	outstandingly bad
elucidate	to make clear
emulate	to imitate in order to equal
ephemeral	short-lived
equivocal	deliberately ambiguous
erudite	learned
exacerbate	to make worse
exonerate	to clear of blame
expedite	to hasten
extraneous	irrelevant, from outside
facilitate	to make easier
fastidious	very attentive to detail
feasible	practicable
fortitude	courage in adversity
frugal	economical, sparing
futile	pointless

5.2 Words G to P

Word	Meaning
garrulous	excessively talkative
germane	relevant to the matter
gregarious	sociable
hackneyed	overused, unoriginal
impartial	unbiased
impeccable	faultless
impetuous	acting rashly
impunity	freedom from punishment
inadvertent	unintentional
incisive	sharp, penetrating
incontrovertible	not open to dispute
indolent	lazy
ineluctable	unavoidable
innocuous	harmless
insidious	proceeding harmfully but unnoticed
intransigent	refusing to compromise
inundate	to flood, overwhelm
irrevocable	not able to be undone
judicious	showing good judgement
laconic	using very few words
latent	present but not visible
laudable	deserving praise
lucid	clear, easily understood

Word	Meaning
magnanimous	generous in spirit
meticulous	extremely careful
mitigate	to make less severe
moot	open to debate
nebulous	vague, ill-defined
obfuscate	to make deliberately unclear
obsolete	out of date
onerous	burdensome
ostensible	apparent but not actual
paucity	scarcity
peremptory	admitting no refusal
perfunctory	done without care, as a formality
pernicious	very harmful
plausible	seeming reasonable
pragmatic	practical rather than theoretical
precarious	insecure, risky
prescient	knowing in advance
prevaricate	to speak evasively
proclivity	a tendency
prodigious	remarkably large
profuse	abundant
prosaic	dull, commonplace
prudent	showing careful judgement
punctilious	strict about detail and correctness

5.3 Words Q to Z

Word	Meaning
quandary	a state of uncertainty
rebuke	to reprimand sharply
recalcitrant	stubbornly resisting authority
reciprocal	mutual, given in return
rectitude	moral uprightness
redundant	superfluous, no longer needed
refute	to prove false
relegate	to consign to a lower position
remiss	negligent in duty
reprehensible	deserving censure
rescind	to cancel, revoke
reticent	reserved, not forthcoming
salient	most noticeable, prominent
sanguine	optimistic
scrupulous	conscientiously exact
scrutinise	to examine closely
spurious	false, not genuine
squander	to waste
stringent	strict, exacting
succinct	brief and clearly expressed
superfluous	more than is needed
surreptitious	done secretly
tacit	understood without being stated

Word	Meaning
tenable	capable of being defended
tenuous	thin, weak
trivial	of little importance
ubiquitous	present everywhere
unequivocal	leaving no doubt
untenable	not capable of being defended
vacillate	to waver between choices
veracity	truthfulness
vehement	showing strong feeling
verbose	using more words than needed
vigilant	watchful
vindicate	to clear of blame; to justify
vociferous	loud and insistent
zealous	fervently devoted

6. Session 6 — Idioms Worth Knowing ★★☆☆☆

Idiom	Meaning
a damp squib	a disappointing anticlimax
hold the fort	to take charge temporarily
a moot point	a matter open to debate
strain credulity	to be difficult to believe
ex parte	in the absence of one party
prima facie	on the face of it, at first sight
bona fide	genuine, in good faith
mutatis mutandis	with the necessary changes made
sine qua non	an indispensable condition
status quo	the existing state of affairs
turn a blind eye	to ignore deliberately
at the eleventh hour	at the last possible moment
a red herring	a misleading distraction
cut no ice	to have no effect
in the doldrums	stagnant, depressed
let the cat out of the bag	to reveal a secret

FROM YOUR OWN WORLD · FOUR OF THESE ARE PART OF YOUR FUTURE JOB

Ex parte, prima facie, bona fide and **sine qua non** are not decorative Latin — they are working terms in the quasi-judicial process F6.1 §1.4 described.

A **Section 7A** determination made without the employer appearing is an **ex parte** order. A **prima facie** case is what justifies opening an inquiry. A **bona fide** dispute is treated differently from an evasion. And a hearing is a **sine qua non** of natural justice — the condition without which the order cannot stand.

So this row of the table is simultaneously English vocabulary and Module 3 procedure. Learn them once and they pay twice, including in the interview.

7. Graded Practice — 40 Questions ★★★★★

Target: 25 seconds per question. Time yourself. F8.0's calendar splits this bank across two evenings in week 1, then re-drills it in weeks 4, 5, 7 and 9.

7.1 Level 1 — Meaning in context

In each question, choose the option closest in meaning to the word in bold.

- Q1.** The auditor's report was **candid** about the lapses in record-keeping. (a) evasive (b) hostile (c) frank (d) cautious
- Q2.** The officer was **reticent** about his reasons for reopening the inquiry. (a) reserved (b) enthusiastic (c) angry (d) confused
- Q3.** The evidence produced by the inspector was **cogent**. (a) irrelevant (b) lengthy (c) doubtful (d) convincing
- Q4.** The scheme has been **defunct** for several years. (a) profitable (b) no longer operating (c) newly started (d) controversial
- Q5.** She showed remarkable **fortitude** during the proceedings. (a) courage in adversity (b) physical strength (c) good fortune (d) stubbornness
- Q6.** The employer's statements were **ambiguous**. (a) precise (b) untrue (c) open to more than one meaning (d) unnecessarily long
- Q7.** The clerk was **meticulous** in checking the wage registers. (a) hasty (b) extremely careful (c) reluctant (d) casual
- Q8.** The employer's conduct in concealing the records was **egregious**. (a) commendable (b) ordinary (c) generous (d) outstandingly bad
- Q9.** The witness gave a **verbose** account of the incident. (a) truthful (b) brief (c) using more words than needed (d) barely audible
- Q10.** The tribunal **exonerated** the employee of all charges. (a) cleared of blame (b) punished (c) transferred (d) suspended
- Q11.** Contributions were withheld with complete **impunity**. (a) great care (b) freedom from punishment (c) severity (d) impartiality
- Q12.** The claim was found to be **spurious**. (a) urgent (b) generous (c) partially valid (d) false
- Q13.** He gave a **succinct** summary of the position. (a) brief and clear (b) rambling (c) inaccurate (d) hesitant
- Q14.** The management was **complacent** about the shortfall in contributions. (a) worried (b) diligent (c) smugly self-satisfied (d) apologetic
- Q15.** On the facts, the proposal is entirely **tenable**. (a) temporary (b) expensive (c) concealed (d) capable of being defended

7.2 Level 2 — Blanks, antonyms and confusable pairs

- Q16.** The Commissioner refused to _____ to pressure from the employer. (a) exceed (b) accede (c) succeed (d) precede
- Q17.** His remarks were _____ to the issue and helped settle it. (a) extraneous (b) hostile (c) germane (d) redundant
- Q18.** Choose the word most nearly **opposite** in meaning to **frugal**. (a) extravagant (b) thrifty (c) careful (d) modest
- Q19.** The vehicle remained _____ at the crossing for several minutes. (a) stationery (b) stationeries (c) stationarily (d) stationary
- Q20.** The auditor's role is to _____ the accounts, not to prepare them. (a) precede (b) scrutinise (c) proscribe (d) prescribe
- Q21.** Choose the option closest in meaning to **ubiquitous**. (a) present everywhere (b) exceedingly rare (c) very ancient (d) wholly unnecessary
- Q22.** The employer attempted to _____ the statute by reclassifying wages as allowances. (a) accentuate (b) corroborate (c) circumvent (d) consolidate
- Q23.** Choose the word most nearly **opposite** in meaning to **ephemeral**. (a) brief (b) lasting (c) fragile (d) concealed
- Q24.** It is a matter of _____, not of money. (a) principal (b) principals (c) principally (d) principle
- Q25.** The two sets of accounts were _____ to identify the discrepancy. (a) relegated (b) replicated (c) reconciled (d) rescinded
- Q26.** Choose the option closest in meaning to **prudent**. (a) showing careful judgement (b) unusually generous (c) hesitant (d) severe
- Q27.** The order of the lower authority was _____ by the appellate authority. (a) ratified (b) reiterated (c) remanded (d) rescinded
- Q28.** A decision is _____; it is expected to be announced today. (a) eminent (b) imminent (c) immanent (d) eminently
- Q29.** The report was strongly _____ of the department's handling of the case. (a) censorious (b) laudatory (c) neutral (d) oblivious
- Q30.** Choose the word most nearly **opposite** in meaning to **lucid**. (a) clear (b) bright (c) confusing (d) straightforward

7.3 Level 3 — Recruitment Test standard

- Q31.** Notwithstanding the employer's _____ protestations of compliance, the inspection revealed systematic under-reporting. (a) sincere (b) vehement (c) reluctant (d) belated
- Q32.** The scheme, though well intentioned, proved to be **a damp squib**. The idiom means (a) an expensive failure (b) a sudden success (c) a hidden danger (d) a disappointing anticlimax

- Q33.** He was asked to **hold the fort** while the Commissioner was on leave. The idiom means to (a) defend a position by force (b) prepare a detailed report (c) take charge temporarily (d) refuse to act
- Q34.** Which one of the following pairs is correctly matched? (a) ingenuous — naive (b) ingenious — naive (c) ingenuous — clever (d) ingenious — sincere
- Q35.** The determination was made **ex parte**, which means (a) after hearing both sides (b) in the absence of one of the parties (c) by mutual consent (d) purely on the merits
- Q36.** The employer's explanation **strained credulity**, meaning that it was (a) legally sound (b) financially costly (c) partially accepted (d) difficult to believe
- Q37.** Far from being _____, the penalty was widely regarded as lenient. (a) draconian (b) modest (c) fair (d) delayed
- Q38.** The two provisions are not in conflict with each other; they are _____. (a) contradictory (b) redundant (c) complementary (d) obsolete
- Q39.** To describe something as **a moot point** is to say that it is (a) already settled (b) trivial (c) extremely urgent (d) open to debate
- Q40.** The officer acted with **alacrity**, that is, with (a) reluctance (b) brisk willingness (c) undue severity (d) carelessness

8. Answers and Explanations

8.1 Level 1

Q	Ans	Explanation
1	c	frank. <i>Candid</i> means open and straightforward, even when the truth is unwelcome
2	a	reserved. <i>Reticent</i> is not-forthcoming. Note it does not mean reluctant or unwilling — a common slippage
3	d	convincing. <i>Cogent</i> argues compellingly
4	b	no longer operating. From the Latin for "having finished"
5	a	courage in adversity. <i>Fortitude</i> is moral endurance, not physical strength — option (b) is the trap
6	c	open to more than one meaning. From ambi- = both (§3.1). Note it does not mean <i>untrue</i>
7	b	extremely careful
8	d	outstandingly bad. From greg = flock (§3.2) — standing out from the herd. And the negative charge of "concealing" eliminates (a) and (c) in two seconds
9	c	using more words than needed. From <i>verb</i> = word
10	a	cleared of blame. From ex- = out of (§3.1) — out of the blame
11	b	freedom from punishment. Literally "without penalty"
12	d	false. <i>Spurious</i> means not genuine
13	a	brief and clear. Note the contrast with <i>verbose</i> in Q9 — the two are near-opposites
14	c	smugly self-satisfied. Not the same as <i>complaisant</i> , which means eager to please
15	d	capable of being defended. From ten = hold (§3.2) — a position that can be held. <i>Untenable</i> is the opposite

8.2 Level 2

Q	Ans	Explanation
16	b	accede = to yield or agree. <i>Exceed</i> is to go beyond — the confusable pair from §4
17	c	germane = relevant. Note the continuation signal "and helped settle it", which requires a positive, relevant word — so <i>extraneous</i> and <i>redundant</i> are ruled out by §2.2
18	a	extravagant . <i>Frugal</i> is sparing, so thrifty, careful and modest are all near-synonyms, not opposites — a three-way distractor set
19	d	stationary = not moving. Station-e-ry with an e is for envelopes
20	b	scrutinise . <i>Proscribe</i> forbids, <i>prescribe</i> recommends — neither is what an auditor does. This is F6.7's point that audit examines rather than prepares
21	a	present everywhere
22	c	circumvent = to get around. From circum- = around (§3.1). Note the negative charge of the sentence
23	b	lasting . <i>Ephemeral</i> is short-lived, so (a) <i>brief</i> is a synonym, not an antonym — the commonest error on antonym questions
24	d	principle = a rule or belief, and the slot after "a matter of" needs a noun (§2.4). The rule ends in -le
25	c	reconciled — brought into agreement. <i>Rescinded</i> means cancelled
26	a	showing careful judgement
27	d	rescinded = cancelled. <i>Ratified</i> is the opposite — approved; <i>remanded</i> means sent back
28	b	imminent = about to happen. <i>Eminent</i> is distinguished; <i>immanent</i> means inherent
29	a	censorious = severely critical. The signal word "strongly" plus the negative framing rules out <i>laudatory</i> and <i>neutral</i>
30	c	confusing . <i>Lucid</i> is clear, so (a), (b) and (d) are all synonyms

8.3 Level 3

Q	Ans	Explanation
31	b	vehement. "Notwithstanding" signals contrast (§2.2): the protestations must have been <i>forceful</i> for the contrast with the finding of bite. <i>Vehement protestations</i> is also the natural collocation (§2.5)
32	d	a disappointing anticlimax — something that fails to go off, like a firework that has got wet
33	c	take charge temporarily
34	a	ingenuous = naive. <i>Ingenious</i> means clever. Options (b), (c) and (d) all cross-match the pair
35	b	in the absence of one of the parties — and, as §6 notes, an <i>ex parte</i> Section 7A order is exactly this
36	d	difficult to believe. From cred = believe (§3.2)
37	a	draconian. "Far from" signals contrast, and the other half says <i>lenient</i> — so the blank must be its opposite. The sentence supplies the answer without any vocabulary at all (§2.2)
38	c	complementary — completing each other. Note the spelling: <i>complementary</i> completes, <i>complimentary</i> praises
39	d	open to debate. The commonest error is to read <i>moot</i> as "settled" or "irrelevant"
40	b	brisk willingness

THINK LIKE UPSC · THE THREE SHAPES IN THIS BANK

- The synonym offered as an antonym.** Q18, Q23 and Q30 each place three near-synonyms of the given word among the options. When a question asks for the **opposite**, the danger is not ignorance but inattention — underline the word "opposite" before reading the options
- The sentence that answers itself.** Q31 and Q37 need no vocabulary. A contrast signal plus the other half of the sentence determines the charge of the missing word. These are the fastest marks in the English block, and they are free
- The cross-matched pair.** Q34 gives you four combinations of two words and two meanings. Only one is right, and knowing *either* word settles it

9. One-Minute Revision

ONE-MINUTE REVISION · CHAPTER F8.1

WEIGHT vocabulary was **10 of the 20 English questions** in 2023 — the highest concentration of any format in the paper · **target 20–30 seconds each**, then move

THE FIVE TECHNIQUES, IN ORDER **1 charge** (positive or negative — eliminate the wrong charge) · **2 signal** (contrast: *but, although, despite, far from* » the blank **opposes**; continuation: *and, moreover, indeed* » it **agrees**) · **3 root** · **4 part of speech** · **5 collocation**

Steps 1 and 2 need no vocabulary at all and resolve many questions in fifteen seconds

PREFIXES **a/an** without · **ambi** both · **anti** against · **circum** around · **ex** out of · **extra** beyond · **mal** bad · **bene** good · **pre** before · **pro** forward or in favour · **sub** under · **super** above · **trans** across

ROOTS **cred** believe · **dict** say · **fid** faith · **greg** flock · **loqu** speak · **path** feeling · **scrib** write · **spec** look · **ten** hold · **ver** truth · **vert** turn · **voc** call

TWO ROOTS THAT PAY **greg = flock** » gregarious, segregate, **egregious** (out of the flock = outstandingly bad) · **scrib = write** » **PREscribe recommends, PROscribe FORBIDS** — near-opposites, routinely paired

CONFUSABLE PAIRS **principle = rule** (the **rule** ends in **-le**) · **stationEry = Envelopes**, **stationary** = at rest · **imminent = about to happen**, **eminent** = distinguished · **ingenuous = naive**, **ingenious** = clever · **discrete = separate**, **discreet** = tactful · **illicit = unlawful**, **elicit** = draw out · **respectively = in the order given**

ANTONYM WARNING when the question asks for the **opposite**, expect three **synonyms** among the options — *frugal / thrifty / careful, ephemeral / brief / fragile, lucid / clear / simple*

IDIOMS **damp squib** = anticlimax · **hold the fort** = take charge temporarily · **moot point** = open to debate · **strain credulity** = hard to believe · **red herring** = misleading distraction · **ex parte** = one party absent · **prima facie** = at first sight · **bona fide** = genuine · **sine qua non** = indispensable condition

THE DRIP ten words a day from §5 · write one sentence of your own for each · test yesterday's ten before taking today's · test all sixty on Saturday · **extend the list from your own reading**

10. Five-Minute Wall Sheet

FIVE-MINUTE WALL SHEET · CHAPTER F8.1

CHARGE FIRST — is the sentence praising or criticising? Kill the wrong charge

CONTRAST WORDS but · although · though · however · whereas · despite · notwithstanding · far from » the blank **OPPOSES** the rest

MAL = BAD · BENE = GOOD · CIRCUM = AROUND · EX = OUT OF · AMBI = BOTH

GREG = FLOCK » EGREGIOUS = OUTSTANDINGLY BAD

PRESCRIBE RECOMMENDS · PROSCRIBE FORBIDS

PRINCIPLE = RULE (-le) · STATIONERY = ENVELOPES (e)

IMMINENT = ABOUT TO HAPPEN · INGENUOUS = NAIVE · DISCRETE = SEPARATE

"OPPOSITE" QUESTIONS HIDE THREE SYNONYMS — underline the word *opposite*

MOOT = OPEN TO DEBATE (not settled) · **DAMP SQUIB = ANTICLIMAX** · **EX PARTE = ONE SIDE ABSENT**

25 SECONDS EACH. ANSWER, MARK, MOVE.

ONE LINE FOR THE INTERVIEW Vocabulary is the one part of this examination that cannot be crammed, because a word is retained through repeated encounter rather than a single effort — which is exactly why ten words a day for twelve weeks beats a fortnight of lists.

ACTION · NEXT

F8.2 — Para Jumbles and Sentence Rearrangement, the second English format, worth 5 of the 20 English questions in 2023.

But before reading it: **do \$7 Q1–20 tomorrow evening**, timed, per F8.0's week 1 Monday cell. The programme works only if the drill starts before the reading is finished.